

Chapter 71 Part 8

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At the same moment, at Ci'ai Orphanage.

Gu Zhaoyuan lay in bed tossing and turning, unable to sleep. Things he had deliberately tried to forget were brought up again. He turned on the light in his room and took out a photo album from the drawer.

Actually, calling it a photo album—it was just three photos.

One was a solo photo of Gu Xingyue standing under a tree. In the photo, she smiled serenely. Another was a photo of him and Gu Xingyue together. At sunset, the two sat side by side on the steps eating bread. That year, Gu Xingyue had just lost her baby teeth¹. The third photo showed their father standing in the middle, holding his hand with one hand and Gu Xingyue's with the other.

His younger sister was someone Father and he had found when coming down from the mountain. At that time, she was wrapped in a cloth bundle and didn't cry. She looked sickly.

It was nighttime then. The stars were bright, and the North Star shone brilliantly in the distant sky.

So they named her Xingyue—Star-Moon.

Xingyue's health wasn't good. She coughed constantly. Father found many doctors for her. They all said she wouldn't live past this year, but later Xingyue miraculously lived year after year.

When Gu Zhaoyuan was young, he often took his sister up the mountain to play. His sister was beautiful but never spoke.

Sometimes the mischievous children in the orphanage would call her a mute.

In the entire orphanage, only he and Xingyue had the surname Gu. Most of the other children had their own names, and those who didn't were given other names by Father.

Gu Zhaoyuan had once asked why, among so many children, only he and his sister called him Father?

Everyone else called him Director.

Father said: "Affinity."

It was such a simple reason that made them into a family.

Actually, all the children in the orphanage younger than him were his younger brothers and sisters, but only Gu Xingyue was different.

He watched Gu Xingyue grow up. Later, his sister kept getting sick—coughing, catching colds, running fevers. Her body was weak. The doctor said she needed a good environment to recuperate.

So Father took her traveling outside, but unexpectedly, they had a car accident.

He hadn't even seen his sister one last time.

Gu Zhaoyuan now thought back to those days spent with his sister—they seemed like another lifetime.

His fingertips caressed the photo as he smiled bitterly and shed a tear.

Then he put down the photo and got up to go to his father's room.

His father's room kept a dim yellow light on year-round. Father had already fallen asleep.

He sat at the edge of his father's bed, staring blankly for a while.

In the middle of the night, his father suddenly furrowed his brows tightly and began talking in his sleep.

"Xingyue..." Father murmured, "Xingyue..."

Gu Zhaoyuan smiled bitterly. "You're thinking of Xingyue too."

Father suddenly opened his eyes and began to cry like a child.

Gu Zhaoyuan immediately patted his back, soothing him in a low voice: "It's okay, it's okay..."

Father cried while asking: "Zhaoyuan, have you seen Xingyue? Did she go up the mountain? I dreamed she went up the mountain and never came back."

"She didn't go up the mountain." Gu Zhaoyuan was already used to such situations. "She's sleeping in her room."

"But I dreamed a bad woman took her away." Father's old tears flowed freely. "My Xingyue, she's suffering."

Gu Zhaoyuan soothed him in a low voice: "No, Xingyue is asleep."

"Then I need to go see her." Father said, getting up. Like a child, he wiped his tears and headed straight out. Gu Zhaoyuan immediately pulled him back. "Father, Xingyue has grown up. She's a young lady now. You can't go into her room."

"But I dreamed someone was beating her." Father raised his hand, his eyes terribly red. He raised his arm high, then brought it down heavily. "Just like this. My Xingyue, she was being beaten and didn't even dare to cry..."

Gu Zhaoyuan was shocked at these words. "Who was beating her?"

Father became crazy and confused again, repeating just those few sentences over and over. The one he recited most was: "My Xingyue..."

Gu Zhaoyuan sighed helplessly and with heartache.

Footnotes:

¹ Lost her baby teeth (換牙, huànyá): Refers to the natural process during childhood when baby teeth fall out and are replaced by permanent teeth, typically occurring between ages 6-12.